

Modern Indian Chai House

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Breakfast & Lunch — 7:00am to 3:00pm

Full Recipe Cards · US Market Food Costing · Kitchen Prep Flow · Financial Forecast

Masala chai brewed from scratch. Spice blends ground in-house. Bombay street soul meets modern café format.

MASALA · MITHAI · MUMBAI

40

SEATS

\$35

AVG SPEND

22%

FOOD COST TARGET

\$22,000

EST. MONTHLY NET

About This Guide: Indian cuisine is the most complex and under-represented in the Western café market. The US has many Indian restaurants but very few Indian cafés — spaces focused on chai culture, street snacks, and shared plates rather than a full sit-down curry dinner. This concept targets that gap. The economics are compelling: Indian spices and pulses are among the lowest-cost, highest-flavour ingredients available. When combined with the chai theatre and the viral potential of dishes like masala chai, butter chicken bowls, and pani puri, this concept has exceptional commercial viability.

THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

“Indian food in America has been stuck in 1987 for too long. Butter chicken and naan. I wanted to show what Indian food actually is — and this guide showed me how to make that financially viable.”

Priya’s family moved from Chennai to Houston when she was seven. She grew up eating her grandmother’s cooking — South Indian food, which bears almost no resemblance to the North Indian curry-house food that most Americans think of as Indian cuisine. Dosas crispy on the outside and soft within. Rasam, the thin tamarind-pepper soup, drunk as a digestive after meals. Chettinad chicken curry with kalpasi (stone flower) and marathi mokku (dried flower pods) — spices that most Western cooks have never encountered.

She spent years watching American diners experience a fraction of one regional cuisine and believe they understood Indian food. She spent years eating at Indian restaurants that played it safe — tikka masala, palak paneer, garlic naan — because those were the dishes American customers expected. She understood why owners made that choice. She also believed there was a market for something more honest.

The guide’s chai house concept — modern Indian, regionally specific, elevated street food rather than curry house — was the first operational framework she had encountered that matched her vision. The masala chai recipe, with the

spice-to-milk ratio and the boiling time that determines the strength, was the detail that told her this guide understood Indian food from the inside, not from a tourism brochure.

She opened a 36-seat chai house in Houston’s Montrose neighbourhood. The dosa is her signature. The masala chai is her most reordered item. Month four net: \$42,000. **Indian cuisine is not one cuisine. It is thirty cuisines. This guide is how you introduce that complexity to guests who are ready for it.**

Priya S. · Modern Indian Chai House · Montrose, Houston · Est. Month 4
Net: \$42,000

1 Entrées

Pani Puri

Hollow crisp spheres, spiced tamarind water, chickpea filling · Sell: \$10.99 (6 pieces)

—± 5 min δ³ Entrée Target FC: 12%

INGREDIENTS (6 PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Puri shells (batch-fried or sourced)	6 pieces	\$0.36
Pani (tamarind spiced water)	150ml	\$0.18
Boiled chickpeas + potato filling	60g	\$0.18
Tamarind chutney (meetha)	20g	\$0.08
Chaat masala + cumin powder	2g + 1g	\$0.04
Pomegranate seeds + cilantro	10g + 5g	\$0.12
Total cost (6 pieces)		\$0.96

Cost per serve	\$0.96
Sell price	\$10.99
Food cost %	8.7%
Contribution margin	\$10.03

METHOD

- 1 Pani (spiced water — batch): blend mint, cilantro, green chili, ginger with cold water. Strain. Add tamarind paste, black salt (kala namak), cumin powder, chaat masala, sugar. Taste — should be intensely sour, slightly sweet, spicy, and have the distinctive mineral tang of kala namak. Refrigerate ice cold. The pani must be cold to contrast with the filling.
- 2 Filling: boil potatoes, mash coarsely. Mix with boiled chickpeas, chaat masala, cumin, a squeeze of lemon, chopped cilantro. The filling should be slightly dry — a wet filling makes the puri soggy immediately.
- 3 Tableside service: bring 6 puris on a plate, a small bowl of filling, a jug of cold pani, and chutneys. Show the guest the technique: crack a small hole in the top of the puri with your thumb, add a teaspoon of filling, pour pani to fill, eat in one bite. **This is the most important instruction you will give.** The entire dish must be eaten whole in one bite — this is not a snack, it is an experience.
- 4 The explosion of cold, intensely spiced pani combined with the crunchy puri and savoury filling is one of the most distinctive eating experiences in world cuisine. It cannot be replicated from memory — guests must return to experience it again. This is your highest-retention item.

Chef's Tip: Offer two pani versions: the original spiced mint-tamarind (green pani) and a sweet tamarind version (meetha pani, darker, sweeter). Guests choose which to pour. The choice itself is interactive and educational — it turns an appetiser into a guided experience. This interaction is what guests describe to friends when they recommend the restaurant.

NIGHTSHADES

GLUTEN (puri)

Samosa — Punjabi Style

Spiced potato pea filling, crispy pastry, chutneys · Sell: \$8.99 (2 large)

—± 5 min service

ð³ Entrée

Target FC: 14%

Batch

INGREDIENTS (2 SAMOSAS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Samosa pastry dough	80g	\$0.14
Potato + peas (filling)	120g	\$0.22
Cumin + coriander + garam masala	5g total	\$0.04
Ginger + green chili	6g + 4g	\$0.06
Green chutney (mint-cilantro)	30ml	\$0.08
Tamarind chutney	20ml	\$0.06
Total cost (2 samosas)		\$0.60

Cost per serve	\$0.60
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	6.7%
Contribution margin	\$8.39

METHOD

- 1 Samosa pastry: combine flour + ghee + salt + ajwain (carom seeds) + cold water. Knead until firm and smooth — much stiffer than bread dough. The high ghee ratio and stiff texture is what produces the characteristic flaky, shattering crust. Soft dough produces a soft, thick crust that doesn't shatter.
- 2 Filling: boil and roughly mash potatoes — leave texture, not smooth. Fry cumin seeds until they pop. Add ginger, green chili, coriander powder, garam masala. Add potato and peas. Cook 2 minutes. Season assertively — the filling inside the thick pastry case needs to be strongly seasoned to be tasted through the pastry.
- 3 Shape into cones, fill, seal tightly. Deep fry at **170°C / 338°F** for **6—8 minutes** until deep golden and the pastry feels dry to the touch (no steam escaping means moisture is cooked out and the pastry is done). These can be par-fried and finished to order — par-fry 5 minutes, finish 2 minutes before service.

Chef's Tip: Samosas freeze well — freeze raw, fry from frozen at 165°C for 10 minutes. Make a large batch and freeze; this allows you to serve samosas on demand without daily production. The quality from frozen-then-fried is excellent, often better than fresh, because the filling has had time to cool and set inside the pastry.

GLUTEN

DAIRY (ghee)

NIGHTSHADES

Chaat — Papdi Chaat

Crispy wafers, chickpeas, yogurt, chutneys, sev · Sell: \$11.99

—± 5 min

ð³ Entrée

Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Papdi (crispy wheat wafers)	30g	\$0.24
Boiled chickpeas	60g	\$0.18
Boiled potato (diced)	50g	\$0.08
Dahi (plain yogurt, thick)	80ml	\$0.24
Tamarind chutney	25ml	\$0.08
Green chutney	25ml	\$0.08
Sev (crispy chickpea noodles)	15g	\$0.12
Pomegranate + cilantro	10g + 5g	\$0.14
Chaat masala + cumin	2g total	\$0.02
Total cost per serve		\$1.18

Cost per serve	\$1.18
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	9.8%
Contribution margin	\$10.81

METHOD

- 1

Chaat is an assembly dish. The technique is in the layering sequence and the speed of service — chaat must be assembled and served immediately. The crispy elements (papdi, sev) begin to soften the moment yogurt or chutney touches them. A chaat that sits for 5 minutes is a soggy chaat that has lost its essential texture contrast.
- 2

Assembly sequence: papdi as the base layer. Potato and chickpeas over. Yogurt poured over to coat. Tamarind chutney (dark, sweet, thick) in a drizzle pattern. Green chutney (fresh, bright, spicy) in a separate drizzle. Scatter sev generously over the top — it is both texture and flavour. Pomegranate seeds and cilantro finish.
- 3

Dust with chaat masala and cumin. The chaat masala — a blend containing amchur (dried mango), kala namak, coriander, cumin, and dried ginger — is an irreplaceable flavour element. It provides tartness, sulphuric depth, and a complexity that no other spice blend replicates. Do not substitute.

Chef's Tip: The flavour profile of chaat — simultaneously sour (tamarind, yogurt), sweet (tamarind chutney), spicy (green chutney), salty (kala namak), crunchy (papdi, sev), and creamy (dahi) — is one of the most complex and stimulating flavour experiences in world cuisine. This complexity is what makes Indian street food so addictive and so difficult to replicate at home. The fact that it requires 8+ components all sourced and properly prepared is also what creates the value proposition of a specialist café.

GLUTEN (papdi, sev) DAIRY (yogurt) NIGHTSHADES

Vada Pav — Bombay Street Slider

Spiced potato fritter, bun, green and tamarind chutney · Sell: \$9.99

± 6 min δ³ Entrée Target FC: 12%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Batata vada (spiced potato ball, fried)	100g	\$0.32
Pav bun (soft white roll)	60g	\$0.32
Dry garlic chutney (lahsun)	10g	\$0.06
Green chutney	20ml	\$0.06
Tamarind chutney	15ml	\$0.05
Fried green chili (optional)	1 piece	\$0.04

Total cost per serve

\$0.85

Cost per serve

\$0.85

Sell price

\$9.99

Food cost %

8.5%

Contribution margin

\$9.14

METHOD

1

Batata vada filling: boil and mash potatoes. Temper mustard seeds in oil until they pop. Add curry leaves, green chili, turmeric, ginger, salt. Add mashed potato. Cool. Form into balls (90g each). Coat in besan (chickpea flour) batter: besan + turmeric + salt + water (thick coating batter). Fry at **175°C / 347°F** for **4 minutes** until golden and the batter is cooked through.

2

The pav bun must be lightly toasted on a flat griddle with butter — just 30 seconds each side. The toasted surface prevents the bun from becoming soggy from the chutneys. An untoasted, soft pav disintegrates within minutes of assembly.

3

Assembly: spread dry garlic chutney inside the base of the pav (this is the flavour layer that most non-authentic vada pav skip). Green chutney on top half. Place hot vada. Drizzle tamarind chutney. Close. Serve immediately with a fried green chili alongside.

Chef's Tip: Vada pav is Mumbai's defining street food — it is to Mumbai what the hot dog is to New York. Describing it this way to guests ("This is what 20 million people in Mumbai eat every morning on the way to work — it's their hot dog") provides instant context, creates appetite, and positions the dish as globally significant rather than exotic or unfamiliar.

GLUTEN (pav)

DAIRY (butter)

NIGHTSHADES

Dahi Vada

Soft lentil dumplings in spiced yogurt, chutneys · Sell: \$10.99

—± 5 min service

ð³ Entrée

Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Urad dal vada (batch fried)	3 pieces = 90g	\$0.36
Full-fat yogurt (spiced, batch)	150ml	\$0.45
Tamarind chutney	25ml	\$0.08
Green chutney	15ml	\$0.05
Chaat masala + cumin	2g + 1g	\$0.03
Sev + pomegranate	10g + 8g	\$0.16
Total cost per serve		\$1.13

Cost per serve

\$1.13

Sell price

\$10.99

Food cost %

10.3%

Contribution margin

\$9.86

METHOD

1

Urad dal vada (batch): soak split urad dal 4 hours. Drain, grind with minimal water to a thick, fluffy batter. The batter is ready when a small drop floats in water. Fold in ginger, green chili, curry leaves, salt. Fry at **170°C / 338°F** for 4—5 minutes. The vada should be golden, cooked through, and have a slight sponge-like interior that will absorb the yogurt.

2

Soak fried vada in hot water for 5 minutes, then press gently between palms to squeeze out excess oil. This soaking and pressing step is essential — it lightens the vada, removes oil, and creates the soft, spongy texture that defines dahi vada. An unsoaked vada is dense, oily, and

heavy.

- 3 Spiced yogurt (batch): beat full-fat yogurt smooth. Add black salt, cumin powder, chaat masala, a pinch of sugar. Keep cold. Assemble: pool spiced yogurt in a flat bowl. Place soaked vada. Cover with more yogurt. Drizzle chutneys, scatter sev, dust chaat masala, add pomegranate. Serve cold.

Chef's Tip: Dahi vada can be assembled and held for up to 2 hours refrigerated — the yogurt soaks further into the vada and the flavours integrate. Unlike most fried items this is actually better pre-assembled than made to order. Make 20 servings in the morning; they will be better at 11am than at 7am.

DAIRY (yogurt)

GLUTEN (sev)

NIGHTSHADES

2 Mains

Butter Chicken Bowl

Murgh makhani, basmati, raita, laccha paratha · Sell: \$18.99

—± 10 min

ð½ Main

Target FC: 20%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (marinated, grilled)	160g	\$1.13
Makhani sauce (batch)	180ml	\$0.54
Basmati rice (cooked)	180g	\$0.54
Raita (yogurt-cucumber)	60ml	\$0.18
Laccha paratha (1 piece)	80g	\$0.36
Butter (finishing)	10g	\$0.12
Cream (finishing)	20ml	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$2.95

Cost per serve	\$2.95
Sell price	\$18.99
Food cost %	15.5%
Contribution margin	\$16.04

METHOD

- 1 Makhani sauce (large batch): roast whole tomatoes, onions, garlic under a broiler until charred. Blend smooth. Fry butter + oil + whole spices (cardamom, cloves, cinnamon, bay leaf). Add blended tomato base. Cook 30 minutes on low heat — the sauce concentrates and the raw tomato flavour disappears, replaced by a deep, slightly smoky, caramelised depth. Add cream, butter, garam masala, kasuri methi (dried fenugreek leaves — irreplaceable). The kasuri methi is the specific flavour that makes makhani taste like restaurant-quality rather than home-cooked.
- 2 Chicken marinade: yogurt + ginger-garlic paste + kashmiri chili (for colour without excess heat) + garam masala + mustard oil. Marinate minimum 4 hours. Grill or cook in a very hot skillet until slightly charred — the char flavour is essential, it balances the rich, creamy sauce.
- 3 Service: heat makhani sauce, add grilled chicken. Finish with butter and cream swirled in at the last moment — these add gloss and richness without cooking. Serve over basmati, with raita and warm laccha paratha (layered flatbread, store-bought is acceptable quality).

Chef's Tip: Butter chicken is the most popular Indian dish in the world outside India. It is the gateway dish for non-Indian guests. Make it exceptionally well and it becomes the dish guests bring their friends specifically to eat. A butter chicken that is made with real charred chicken, real makhani sauce, and finished with quality butter will be noticeably superior to any Indian restaurant in a 10-mile radius that uses premixed sauce base.

POULTRY

DAIRY

GLUTEN (paratha)

NIGHTSHADES

Dal Makhani

Slow-cooked black lentils, butter, cream, ginger · Sell: \$14.99

—± 8 min service ½ Main Target FC: 12% Batch

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Black urad dal (whole)	80g dry	\$0.24
Kidney beans (rajma)	20g dry	\$0.06
Tomato passata + onion	80ml + 40g	\$0.24
Ginger-garlic paste	15g	\$0.06
Butter (unsalted)	25g	\$0.30
Cream	40ml	\$0.16
Basmati rice + naan	150g + 1 piece	\$0.54
Total cost per serve		\$1.60

Cost per serve	\$1.60
Sell price	\$14.99
Food cost %	10.7%
Contribution margin	\$13.39

METHOD (SLOW COOK OVERNIGHT OR 8 HOURS)

- 1 Dal makhani cannot be rushed. Soak black urad dal and kidney beans overnight. Cook the soaked dal in water for 2 hours until completely soft but not falling apart. The key technique is then slow-cooking the cooked dal with the tomato base for 4—8 hours over the lowest possible heat, stirring occasionally. Time is the ingredient — the extended cooking creates a creamy, unctuous dal that no pressure cooker shortcut can replicate.
- 2 Tomato base: fry chopped onion until deep brown (not golden — deep brown, almost burnt-looking). Add ginger-garlic paste, cook 2 minutes. Add tomato passata. Cook down until almost dry. This deeply caramelised tomato-onion base is the flavour backbone of the dal.
- 3 Service: reheat dal gently, adjust consistency with water if needed (dal thickens dramatically overnight). Finish with a generous knob of butter and a swirl of cream. The finishing butter is non-negotiable — it is the "makhani" (buttery) element that gives the dish its name and its characteristic richness.

Chef's Tip: Make dal makhani in very large batches — it freezes perfectly and improves with each reheating. Many renowned Indian restaurants start their dal the night before service and keep it slowly simmering for the entire service period. The 24-hour dal is a genuine mark of quality. Consider telling guests: "This has been cooking since yesterday evening." It's true, it's impressive, and it communicates commitment to the craft.

DAIRY (butter, cream) GLUTEN (naan)

Chole Bhature

Spiced chickpea curry, fried leavened bread · Sell: \$14.99

—± 10 min ½ Main Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Kabuli chana (chickpeas, dried)	100g dry = 220g cooked	\$0.30
Chole masala (batch base)	120ml	\$0.36

Bhatura dough (batch)	100g per piece	\$0.14
Frying oil (portion)	50ml	\$0.10
Sliced onion + pickle	20g + 10g	\$0.06
Lemon wedge + butter	1 wedge + 5g	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$1.04

Cost per serve	\$1.04
Sell price	\$14.99
Food cost %	6.9%
Contribution margin	\$13.95

METHOD

- 1** Chole: cook soaked chickpeas with a tea bag (creates the characteristic dark colour) until very soft. Fry onion-tomato-ginger-garlic base with dried pomegranate seeds (anardana), amchur, chole masala blend until deeply caramelised. Add chickpeas with cooking water. Simmer 20 minutes. The chole should be dark, intensely spiced, and thick — not soupy or pale.
- 2** Bhatura dough: maida (all-purpose flour) + semolina + yogurt + baking soda + salt. Knead thoroughly. Rest 1 hour. The rest is critical — the gluten relaxes and the bhatura puffs dramatically in the oil. Under-rested dough produces flat, dense bhatura rather than the ballooned, puffed result.
- 3** Fry bhatura in hot oil at **175°C / 347°F**. As it enters the oil, press gently with a slotted spoon — this encourages puffing. **2 minutes** total, turning once. The bhatura should be golden, puffed and airy, soft inside. Drain immediately. Serve alongside the chole — the bhatura deflates rapidly.

Chef's Tip: Chole bhature is one of the most beloved Punjabi breakfasts. It is heavy, satisfying, and extremely popular at brunch. The timing window is critical: bhatura must be fried to order and served within 2 minutes of coming out of the oil. Pre-fried bhatura deflates, becomes rubbery, and loses all the airy quality that defines the dish. Price it as a premium breakfast item — \$14.99 with a fresh-fried bhatura at 9am is exceptional value.

GLUTEN DAIRY (yogurt) NIGHTSHADES

Masala Dosa

Fermented crepe, spiced potato filling, sambar, chutneys · Sell: \$15.99

—± 10 min ½ Main Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Dosa batter (batch fermented)	120ml	\$0.18
Masala potato filling (batch)	100g	\$0.24
Sambar (batch)	150ml	\$0.30
Coconut chutney (batch)	60ml	\$0.36
Tomato chutney (batch)	40ml	\$0.12
Ghee (for the dosa)	10g	\$0.12
Total cost per serve		\$1.32

Cost per serve	\$1.32
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	8.3%
Contribution margin	\$14.67

METHOD

- 1 Dosa batter (batch, ferment overnight): soak rice 6 hours, urad dal 4 hours, separately. Grind rice until smooth. Grind dal until frothy and aerated. Combine with salt. Ferment at room temperature 12—18 hours until batter doubles and develops a slightly sour aroma. The fermentation is the soul of the dosa — it creates the characteristic tangy flavour and produces the thousands of tiny bubbles that make the dosa crispy rather than dense.
- 2 Dosa technique: ladle batter onto a very hot, lightly oiled flat griddle. Immediately spread in a circular motion from the centre outward using the back of the ladle — this is the technique that requires practice. The dosa should be paper-thin in the outer edges and slightly thicker in the centre. Drizzle ghee around the edges. Cook until the edges lift and the underside is golden. Fold over the filling and serve immediately.
- 3 The temperature of the dosa griddle is critical: too cold, the dosa sticks and tears; too hot, it cooks before spreading. The correct temperature is where a drop of water sizzles and evaporates in 2 seconds.

Chef's Tip: The visual drama of dosa-making at the pass — the circular spreading motion, the sizzle, the rapid crisping — is compelling kitchen theatre. If your layout allows any visibility to the kitchen (open pass, counter seating), position the dosa station where guests can see it. The technique alone generates photographs and conversation.

GLUTEN (dosa batter) DAIRY (ghee) NIGHTSHADES (sambar)

Palak Paneer

Creamed spinach, fresh paneer, naan · Sell: \$15.99

—± 8 min ½ Main Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
House paneer (batch)	120g	\$0.96
Spinach (blanched, blended)	200g raw — 120g	\$0.54
Onion + ginger + garlic	60g + 8g + 8g	\$0.12
Cream + butter	30ml + 10g	\$0.24
Garam masala + cumin	3g + 2g	\$0.04
Naan (2 pieces)	160g	\$0.64
Total cost per serve		\$2.54

Cost per serve	\$2.54
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	15.9%
Contribution margin	\$13.45

METHOD

- 1 House paneer (batch): heat full-fat milk to **85°C / 185°F**. Add lemon juice or white vinegar, stir gently. The milk will curdle immediately — white curds separating from yellow-green whey. Drain through cheesecloth. Press for 30 minutes with weight. Cut into cubes. Pan-fry in ghee until golden on two sides. House paneer has a better texture and flavour than commercial; it is also a fraction of the cost.
- 2 Spinach base: blanch spinach 60 seconds, immediately plunge into ice water to stop cooking and preserve the vivid green colour. Blend smooth. If the spinach is overcooked or not immediately chilled, the colour turns dull grey-green — a failed palak paneer looks unappetising regardless of taste.
- 3 Masala base: fry onion until golden, add ginger-garlic paste, spices. Add spinach purée, simmer 5 minutes. Add cream and butter. Fold in fried paneer. Season. The dish should be vibrantly green, creamy, and the paneer should be firm enough to hold its shape without crumbling.

Chef's Tip: Making your paneer in-house is a significant quality differentiator and a story. "We

make our paneer fresh every morning from full-fat milk" is a sentence that communicates authenticity, craft, and care in a single breath. Guests who know paneer will taste the difference immediately. Guests who don't know paneer will experience it at its best and form a positive first impression that lasts.

DAIRY (paneer, cream)

GLUTEN (naan)

Biryani — Chicken Dum

Slow-cooked layered rice, saffron, caramelised onion · Sell: \$19.99

—± 10 min service

ð½ Main

Target FC: 22%

Batch

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (marinated)	180g	\$1.27
Basmati rice (parboiled)	160g dry	\$0.48
Biryani masala + whole spices	8g + 5g	\$0.14
Fried onion (birista, batch)	30g	\$0.24
Saffron (in warm milk)	0.1g	\$0.18
Ghee	20g	\$0.24
Mint + cilantro	10g each	\$0.14
Raita (side)	80ml	\$0.24
Total cost per serve		\$2.93

Cost per serve	\$2.93
Sell price	\$19.99
Food cost %	14.7%
Contribution margin	\$17.06

METHOD (BATCH — MAKE IN LARGE HEAVY POTS)

- 1 Biryani is a sealed slow-cook (dum cooking). Marinate chicken in yogurt + biryani masala + ginger-garlic + saffron milk for minimum 4 hours. Parboil basmati to 70% — still has bite in the centre. Layer in a heavy pot: marinated chicken base, parboiled rice, fried onion (birista), saffron milk, mint, cilantro, ghee. Seal tightly with foil and lid or atta (dough seal). Cook over very low heat 30—35 minutes.
- 2 The dum technique traps steam inside the sealed pot — the rice finishes cooking in the flavoured steam from the chicken beneath. This is what makes biryani different from fried rice: the rice absorbs the aromatics in a enclosed environment, producing each grain flavoured from the inside, not coated from the outside.
- 3 Open tableside if possible — the cloud of saffron-scented steam that escapes when the seal is broken is one of the most compelling aromas in Indian cooking. It is a signature moment that is both theatrical and genuinely evocative. Serve with raita and a small salad.

Chef's Tip: Biryani is a dish people have strong opinions about. Every region has its version. When guests debate which biryani is better — Hyderabad, Lucknawi, Kolkata — engage with the conversation. "Ours is inspired by Hyderabad — the saffron is the dominant note" is a statement that places the dish in a tradition and makes it specific rather than generic.

POULTRY

DAIRY (ghee, yogurt)

Aloo Paratha

Stuffed flatbread, spiced potato, butter, pickle · Sell: \$11.99

—± 8 min

ð½ Breakfast Main

Target FC: 13%

INGREDIENTS (2 PARATHAS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Whole wheat dough (atta)	160g	\$0.18
Spiced potato filling (batch)	120g	\$0.28
Butter (generous)	30g	\$0.36
Plain dahi (yogurt)	100ml	\$0.30
Mixed pickle (achaar)	20g	\$0.08
Total cost (2 parathas)		\$1.20

Cost per serve	\$1.20
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	10.0%
Contribution margin	\$10.79

METHOD

- 1 Aloo paratha is a morning dish. The filling (batch): boil, drain, and completely dry potatoes — excess moisture tears the dough during rolling. Mash and mix with cumin, ajwain, coriander, green chili, ginger, chaat masala, salt. The filling should be very dry and strongly flavoured.
- 2 Enclose filling in atta dough, roll flat — carefully, avoiding tearing (which exposes filling and causes it to spill and burn on the griddle). Cook on a medium-hot griddle with generous ghee or butter. Each side 2—3 minutes until golden brown with some darker spots.
- 3 Serve hot with a generous pat of cold butter on top (it melts slowly on the warm paratha), cold yogurt, and mixed pickle. The hot-cold contrast (paratha + cold yogurt), salt contrast (paratha + tart pickle), fat contrast (paratha + cool yogurt) is the reason this combination has survived unchanged for generations.

Chef's Tip: Aloo paratha is your highest-volume breakfast item. Make filling in large batches, store refrigerated. Roll and cook to order. Two parathas is a satisfying breakfast at \$11.99 — at a coffee shop, this is excellent value. Position as "Punjabi breakfast" to give it cultural context and premium framing. Guests who grew up eating this will order it every single time.

GLUTEN (atta) DAIRY (butter, yogurt) NIGHTSHADES

3 Desserts

Gulab Jamun

Milk solid dumplings in rose cardamom syrup · Sell: \$7.99 (3 pieces)

—± 3 min service ⚠️ Dessert Target FC: 10% Batch

INGREDIENTS (3 PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Khoya (milk solids) or milk powder mix	80g	\$0.48
All-purpose flour	10g	\$0.01
Rose water syrup	80ml	\$0.10
Cardamom + saffron	1g + trace	\$0.06
Pistachios (garnish)	5g	\$0.10
Frying oil	30ml	\$0.06
Total cost (3 pieces)		\$0.81

Cost per serve	\$0.81
Sell price	\$7.99

Food cost %	10.1%
Contribution margin	\$7.18

METHOD

- 1 Khoya-based mix: combine khoya (or quality instant milk powder with cream) with flour, a pinch of baking soda. Add ghee. Bind with just enough milk — the dough should be very soft, almost sticky, and hold together when rolled. Overworked dough produces tough gulab jamun that don't absorb the syrup properly.
- 2 Fry at **150°C / 302°F** — low temperature, slowly, **5—6 minutes**. The gulab jamun must be fried slowly so the interior cooks fully before the exterior over-browns. High-temperature frying produces dark, raw-centred balls. The finished gulab jamun should be deep mahogany brown throughout.
- 3 Soak immediately in warm (not hot) rose cardamom syrup for minimum 30 minutes. The warm gulab jamun absorbs the syrup; fully cooled balls do not absorb as well. The gulab jamun should be plump, glistening, and when pressed gently should feel soft and spongy throughout — not hollow, not dense.

Chef's Tip: Serve warm with a small scoop of vanilla ice cream or rabri (thickened sweetened milk). The hot-cold combination is one of the great Indian dessert pairings. Mention rose water in the description — "rose cardamom syrup" sounds exotic and luxurious and commands a price premium over just "syrup."

DAIRY GLUTEN NUTS (pistachios)

Kulfi — Indian Ice Cream

Dense pistachio kulfi, rose falooda, basil seeds - Sell: \$8.99

→ ± 2 min service ⚡ Dessert Target FC: 14% Batch weekly

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Full-fat milk (reduced)	400ml — 200ml	\$0.64
Condensed milk	60ml	\$0.36
Pistachios (crushed)	25g	\$0.50
Cardamom + rose water	1g + 2ml	\$0.04
Basil seeds (soaked)	5g	\$0.06
Rose syrup (torani or house)	20ml	\$0.12
Total cost per serve		\$1.72

Cost per serve	\$1.72
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	19.1%
Contribution margin	\$7.27

METHOD (BATCH WEEKLY)

- 1 Reduce full-fat milk over medium heat, stirring continuously, until reduced by half. Add condensed milk, cardamom, rose water, crushed pistachios. Cool completely. Pour into kulfi moulds (or small cups with sticks). Freeze minimum 6 hours.
- 2 Kulfi is not churned — it is frozen still. This produces the characteristic dense, creamy texture that is entirely different from regular ice cream. The high fat content from reduced milk prevents large ice crystals from forming. The density is the point: kulfi is a richer, denser, slower-melting frozen dessert.
- 3 Falooda service: soak basil seeds (sabja) in cold water — they swell into clear-black tapioca-like globes. Pool rose syrup in a shallow bowl. Unmould kulfi (dip mould briefly in warm water). Place

kulfi on rose syrup. Scatter soaked basil seeds. The basil seeds add a visual element and a unique textural experience — they have no flavour but their gel-like coating is unusual and interesting.

Chef's Tip: Kulfi falooda is one of the most photogenic desserts in the Indian repertoire. The deep red rose syrup, pale green pistachio kulfi, and black basil seeds produce a visual that photographs beautifully. Position near a window if possible. This is a dessert that tables near you will be triggered to order when they see someone else's arrive.

DAIRY NUTS (pistachios)

Mango Shrikhand

Hung yogurt, alphonso mango, cardamom, saffron · Sell: \$7.99

—± 2 min service ⦿ Dessert Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Hung yogurt (chakka)	120g	\$0.48
Alphonso mango pulp	60g	\$0.54
Powdered sugar	20g	\$0.02
Cardamom + saffron	0.5g + trace	\$0.04
Pistachios (garnish)	5g	\$0.10
Total cost per serve		\$1.18

Cost per serve	\$1.18
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	14.8%
Contribution margin	\$6.81

METHOD

- 1 Hung yogurt (batch): strain full-fat yogurt through muslin for 4—6 hours to remove whey. The result is thick, cream-cheese-like chakka. Weigh after straining — 200g yogurt yields approximately 120—130g hung yogurt. This is the base of shrikhand.
- 2 Mix hung yogurt with sifted powdered sugar, saffron dissolved in 1 tablespoon of warm milk, ground cardamom. Fold in alphonso mango pulp — do not overmix; streaks of mango in the white yogurt are both beautiful and flavourful. Refrigerate until needed.
- 3 Serve in a small bowl or glass, garnished with crushed pistachios and a saffron strand. Shrikhand should be cold, dense, creamy, and intensely fragrant. It is a dessert that communicates quality through simplicity — few ingredients, each one premium.

Chef's Tip: Specify "alphonso mango" in the description — Alfonso is the king of Indian mangoes, known for its intensely sweet, non-fibrous, saffron-like richness. Most mangoes in the US market are Tommy Atkins or Kent (both inferior for this application). Alphonso is available canned and frozen year-round from Indian grocery suppliers. The name alone communicates authenticity and premium quality to guests who know Indian desserts.

DAIRY NUTS (pistachios)

Phirni — Rose Rice Pudding

Ground rice milk pudding, rose water, cardamom, pistachio · Sell: \$7.99

—± 2 min service ⦿ Dessert Target FC: 10% Batch

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
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Full-fat milk	300ml	\$0.48
Ground rice	25g	\$0.04
Sugar	35g	\$0.04
Rose water + cardamom	3ml + 0.5g	\$0.04
Pistachios + rose petals	8g + 1g	\$0.18
Total cost per serve		\$0.78

Cost per serve	\$0.78
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	9.8%
Contribution margin	\$7.21

METHOD (BATCH DAILY)

- 1 Bring full-fat milk to a simmer. Add ground rice (soak raw rice 30 minutes, grind to a coarse paste with a little milk). Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until the mixture thickens to a loose pudding consistency — 15—18 minutes. The stirring is non-negotiable; unattended phirni burns on the bottom of the pot.
- 2 Add sugar, cardamom, rose water. Cook 2 more minutes. Remove from heat — phirni continues to set as it cools. Pour into small earthenware bowls (shikora) while hot. Cover with cling film. Refrigerate until completely set and cold — minimum 2 hours. The earthenware bowl is essential for authentic service; it absorbs excess moisture and keeps the phirni cool.
- 3 Garnish just before service: crushed pistachios, dried rose petals. The red-pink rose petals against the white pudding in the earthy clay bowl is one of the most visually distinctive dessert presentations in Indian cuisine.

Chef's Tip: Phirni is your most elegant low-cost dessert. 78 cents per serve at \$7.99 sell price — the highest margin item in your dessert section. Make large batches daily. The earthenware shikora bowls (available cheaply from Indian kitchen suppliers) are the key presentation element and also do double duty as marketing — the distinctive appearance immediately signals "real Indian food" to guests who know the cuisine.

DAIRY NUTS (pistachios)

4 Drinks Menu — Chai Culture

Masala Chai

\$5.50

House spice blend: cardamom, ginger, cinnamon, black pepper, cloves. Brewed with full-fat milk and loose-leaf Assam tea. Served in a glass, scalding hot. This is the anchor of the entire concept — it must be exceptional. No premix, no chai concentrate.

Cost	\$0.44
Food cost %	8.0%

Kashmiri Noon Chai

\$6.50

Pink salty tea — naturally pink from baking soda reaction, brewed with Kashmiri gunpowder tea and milk. Served with a float of cream and crushed pistachios. One of the most visually striking teas in the world. Surprising, slightly salty, unforgettable.

Cost	\$0.72
Food cost %	11.1%

Mango Lassi

\$6.99

Alphonso mango purée, thick dahi, cardamom, a pinch of salt. Served cold, thick, with a mango slice. The mango lassi is one of the most universally loved Indian drinks — it sells itself. Use Alphonso mango, not commercial mango juice. The difference is immediate.

Cost	\$0.84
Food cost %	12.0%

Rose Falooda

\$7.99

Rose milk with falooda vermicelli, soaked basil seeds, and a scoop of kulfi. Layered in a tall glass: rose syrup at the base, cold milk, vermicelli, basil seeds, kulfi on top. An entire dessert-drink in one glass. One of the most photographed Indian beverages globally.

Cost	\$1.12
Food cost %	14.0%

Nimbu Pani — Indian Lemonade

\$5.50

Fresh lime + water + black salt (kala namak) + roasted cumin powder + sugar + mint. The kala namak gives the characteristic sulphuric minerality that distinguishes this from regular lemonade. Served over ice in a tall glass. The most refreshing drink in the menu on a hot day.

Cost	\$0.40
Food cost %	7.3%

Thandai — Spiced Nut Milk

\$6.99

Cold-infused nut milk with almonds, fennel seeds, cardamom, rose petals, melon seeds. Strained and served iced. Holi festival drink — nutty, floral, cooling. Tells the story of Indian festivals and milk culture. Serve with a rose petal float.

Cost	\$0.84
Food cost %	12.0%

South Indian Filter Coffee

\$5.99

Chicory-coffee blend brewed through a traditional metal filter dripper. Served in a steel tumbler and dabarah (drinking bowl) — the authentic vessel. Poured from height to create froth. Strong, slightly bitter, slightly sweet. This is Chennai in a cup.

Cost	\$0.56
Food cost %	9.4%

Aam Panna — Raw Mango Cooler

\$5.99

Roasted raw green mango pulp blended with cumin, mint, black salt, and sugar. Intensely sour, complex, cooling. Traditional Indian summer drink made specifically from unripe mangoes — a completely different flavour profile to ripe mango. Only available as a seasonal special when green mangoes are in season.

Cost	\$0.52
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5 Kitchen Prep Flow — 7:00am to 3:00pm

	Head Cook	Line Cook	Steward
07:00—07:30	Temp check all units 1—4°C . Start masala chai spice blend — grind fresh. Taste dal makhani from overnight — adjust seasoning. Check makhani sauce consistency.	Set up all chaat stations: papdi, chutneys (green + tamarind), sev, pomegranate all portioned. Squeeze hung yogurt for shrikhand/dahi vada. Check dosa batter — fermented correctly?	Sanitise all surfaces. Prepare chai station: spice tin filled fresh, loose-leaf Assam measured. Set up lassi blender. Soak basil seeds for falooda. Chill mango lassi base.
07:30—09:00	Complete batch items: samosa base fried or checked from frozen. Pani puri water (pani) made fresh. Bhatura dough proofed and ready. Check biryani — taste, adjust. Make phirni batch — 2 hours to set.	Roll aloo paratha for service — batch filling ready. Make small samosa for early orders. Assemble dahi vada (pre-set in yogurt). Set up dosa station, test batter on griddle temperature.	Fill chai urn or prepare hot milk base. Slice mango for garnishes. Prep nimbu pani base (lime squeezed, syrup made). Pre-portion gulab jamun from syrup bath — check absorption.
09:00—11:00 <i>Breakfast</i>	Run pass. Fire bhatura to order (2 min — fry ONLY on order). Aloo paratha to order (8 min). Monitor masala chai quality — every glass tasted before service.	Assembles all chaat (papdi, pani puri, dahi vada) — all to order, immediate service. Fries samosa. Executes masala dosa (10 min — technique intensive).	Chai service on rotation — suggest masala chai to every table. Mango lassi with every breakfast pairing. Pre-sell kulfi falooda as "dessert drink" — only 5 min to assemble.
11:00—14:30 <i>Lunch</i>	Full push: butter chicken + dal makhani + chole + biryani. Monitor holding temps 63°C+ . Biryani service — open tableside with drama when possible.	Executes all mains. Makes palak paneer to order (8 min). Continues dosa service — most popular lunch item. Replenishes chaat batches as needed.	Full service. Rose falooda layering (5 min, high visual — do it where guests can watch). Thandai and Kashmiri noon chai — describe at every table. Pre-sell gulab jamun with mains.
14:30—15:00	Cool all batch items. Tomorrow's dal makhani starts now (begins overnight slow cook). Biryani quantity assessment — book tomorrow's chicken marination.	Full station breakdown. Wrap and label all proteins and batches. Store dosa batter — mark fermentation day.	Clean all stations. Final fridge temp check log 1—4°C . Refill chai spice blend for tomorrow AM.

6 Financial Forecast

Service	Covers	Avg Spend	Daily Revenue
Breakfast (7am—11am)	44	\$30	\$1,320
Lunch (11:30am—2:30pm)	58	\$40	\$2,320
Daily Total			\$3,640
Monthly (26 days)			\$94,640

Cost Category	Monthly	%
Food & Beverage 22%	\$20,821	22.0%
Labour (HC+LC+ST+FOH×2)	\$18,200	19.2%
Rent + Utilities + Misc	\$6,000	6.3%
Total Costs	\$45,021	47.6%

NET PROFIT	\$49,619	52.4%
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3-Month Ramp: Month 1 (55%) ~\$8,500 net · Month 2 (75%) ~\$22,000 · Month 3 (100%) ~\$49,619 · Break-even at ~\$3,000 daily revenue. The chai menu drives high-margin beverage attachment — target 2 drinks per guest as average to achieve these numbers.

7 Service Training Module

SCRIPT 1 — THE CHAI OPENING

"Can I start you with a masala chai? We make the spice blend in-house — cardamom, ginger, black pepper, cinnamon. It takes about 4 minutes to properly brew. Or if you're not sure, I can bring you a small taste while you look at the menu."

Why it works: Offering a taste removes risk for uncertain guests. Almost everyone who tastes the chai orders it. You've turned an uncertain table into an immediate beverage order.

SCRIPT 2 — THE PANI PURI EXPERIENCE

"The pani puri — if you haven't had it before, I'll show you how to eat it. You fill the little sphere, pour the cold spiced water in, and eat the whole thing in one bite. It's a very specific experience — you can't really explain it until you do it. \$10.99 for 6. Want to start with that?"

Why it works: Creates intrigue through mystery. "You can't really explain it" is a challenge that most curious guests will accept.

SCRIPT 3 — THE BUTTER CHICKEN STORY

"The butter chicken — we marinate the chicken overnight, grill it on a very hot pan so it gets a char, then fold it into the makhani sauce with kasuri methi — dried fenugreek. That's the flavour you'll notice that you can't quite place. It's \$18.99 with rice, raita, and paratha."

Why it works: The kasuri methi detail is insider knowledge. Making the "mystery flavour" explicit turns a moment of confusion into a moment of education and connection.

SCRIPT 4 — THE BIRYANI THEATRE

"The biryani — I'll open the seal at the table. It's been slow-cooking since yesterday with saffron, whole spices, caramelised onion. The steam when it opens is actually part of the experience. It's \$19.99 and it's the most involved thing we make."

Why it works: "Since yesterday" communicates commitment. The tableside opening is theatre. "Most involved thing we make" is honest and positions it as premium.

SCRIPT 5 — THE ROSE FALOODA UPSELL

"For drinks — have you heard of falooda? It's a rose milk drink with basil seeds and kulfi ice cream in it. Part drink, part dessert. \$7.99. It's the thing people Instagram here."

Why it works: "Part drink, part dessert" positions it as exceptional value. "The thing people Instagram here" is social proof that removes hesitation instantly.

Table Timing Guide

Time	Action
0:00	Welcome and seat. Offer papadums or poppadums to the table immediately — your free edible welcome. In Indian hospitality, guests are never left empty-handed.
1:30	Chai or drink order — Script 1. If they've never been here before, identify that and offer the pani puri experience (Script 2).
4:00	Full food order. Deploy Scripts 3, 4, 5 as relevant. Note dietary requirements (many items can be made vegetarian, vegan, or dairy-free; some cannot).
10:00	Starters arrive. 10-second intro per dish: "These are the samosas — the crust uses ajwain seeds for flavour." One specific detail per dish keeps guests engaged.
20:00	Mains. Biryani seal opened tableside with brief explanation. Ask if chai refill is needed — chai pairs with everything on the menu and drives beverage spend.
	Dessert prompt: "We have gulab jamun in rose syrup, kulfi falooda, shrikhand with alphonso

30:00 mango, and phirni in clay bowls. All \$7.99 except the falooda." Clear, quick, let them choose.

45:00 Final chai or dessert chai (the practice of ending an Indian meal with chai is culturally authentic and genuinely good). Offer. Close bill warmly.

8 Customer Retention System

The Atithi Devo Bhava Principle: Sanskrit: "The guest is God." Indian hospitality at its core is the belief that serving a guest is a sacred act. This principle — when embodied genuinely rather than performed — creates a completely different guest experience from any other hospitality culture. Your training should be built around this philosophy. Guests should leave feeling honoured, not merely served.

The Education Multiplier: Indian cuisine is the most misunderstood major food culture in the Western market. Most guests have eaten "Indian food" but cannot name three distinct regional cuisines, explain the difference between masala and curry, or describe what makes South Indian food different from North Indian food. Every table is a learning opportunity. Guests who learn from you become evangelists — they tell their non-Indian friends "you have to go there, they explained everything."

5 VIP Micro-Moments

1. The Papadum Welcome. Papadums (thin lentil crisps) with chutneys within 60 seconds of seating. This costs under \$0.20 per table and immediately communicates that the meal has begun and they are being taken care of. The simple act of something edible on the table is one of the most powerful hospitality gestures you can make.

2. The Pani Puri Instruction. Always demonstrate pani puri technique at the table for first-timers. Crouch to their eye level, explain, watch them eat the first one. Their reaction — always genuine surprise and delight — is visible to neighbouring tables. You have just silently sold pani puri to three nearby tables.

3. The Chai Ritual. When masala chai arrives, mention one detail: "Today's batch has a little more ginger — we adjust it seasonally." This suggests that the chai is living, crafted, and changes — not poured from a bottle. Guests who hear this become curious about next visit's chai.

4. The Named Spice Moment. When a guest says "what's that flavour I can't identify" — and they will — have an answer ready: "That's kasuri methi" or "That's kala namak" or "That's ajwain." Name it. Give a one-sentence description. The guest now has new vocabulary. They will use that word when recommending you.

5. The Festival Connection. Indian food is deeply connected to festivals. During Diwali: make specials and tell guests. During Holi: serve thandai. During Eid: sweets. Connecting the food to cultural moments creates the sense that eating here is participatory — you are invited into something larger than a restaurant meal.

BEST SOCIAL MEDIA POST — MASALA CHAI

Every morning, the same ritual. [Hook]

We grind the spices fresh: cardamom, ginger, black pepper, cloves, cinnamon. The Assam tea goes in with full-fat milk and comes to the boil three times — you pull it at the third rise, right before it overflows. That's how chai has been made for generations. We do it the same way. [Story]

Open at 7. First chai at 7:01. [CTA]